



Comhairle Cathrach
& Contae **Luimnigh**

Limerick City
& County Council

Minutes of the Meeting of Limerick City and County Council's Travel and Transportation Strategic Policy Committee held on 19th February 2025 at 3:00 p.m. in the Council Chamber, Dooradoyle and ONLINE by MS Teams Video Conference.

Members Present: Cllrs. Teefy (Chair), Butler, Kilcoyne, Gavan, Hartigan, O'Donoghue, O'Donovan, E. Ryan, Ruddle, Scanlon, Secas, Teskey, Mrs. M. Browne, Mr. Farron Flaherty, Mr. Seán Golden, Mr. John Foster, Mr. Dan O'Neill.

Apologies:

Cllr. M. Ryan & Mr. Philip Ruttle.

Other invitees:

Cllrs. S. Kiely, J. Pond, J. Leddin.

Officials Present: Mr. B. Kennedy, Ms. A. Leahy, Mr. B. Barrett, Ms. C. Larkin, Mr. D. Slavin, Mr. J. Cregan, Mr. H. McGrath, Mr. J. Gannon, Ms. K. McDonnell, Mr. L. Browne, Ms. M. Hennessy, Ms. M. Corrigan, Ms. M. Fitzgerald, Ms. N. McGarry, Mr. R. Gorey, Mr. S. McGlynn, Ms. S. Kennedy, Ms. T. Flanagan, Mr. T. Hayes, Mr. T. Goodwin.

The Chair opened the meeting and welcomed all the members to the first SPC meeting. Before proceedings began, the Chair wished to extend her condolences to the family on the death of the late Eddie Wade, former Councillor for 35 years and also a former Fianna Fáil TD. The members stood for a minute's silence to honour the late Cllr. Wade.

The chair invited all in the chamber to introduce themselves and Mr. Kennedy welcomed all the new members of the committee.

Item 1: Minutes:

The Minutes of the Meeting of the Travel and Transportation Strategic Policy Committee held on the 23rd April 2024 were proposed by Cllr. E. O'Donovan and seconded by Cllr. John O'Donoghue and adopted.

Item 2: Presentation: Community Hedge cutting Scheme – John Gannon, S.E.

Mr. Gannon delivered a presentation outlining the Community Hedge Cutting Grant Scheme and how it will be administered. The application is currently in draft form with €50,000 revenue budget being secured for 2025.

The members thanked Mr. Gannon and the Chair opened the floor to Questions –

Cllr. Kiely asked who will perform the inspections and will more funding become available when budget is spent. Cllr. Pond asked if all landowners are required to come on board and gave an example of one landowner on same length of road not wishing to engage in group application.

In response Mr. Gannon advised that District office Engineers will carry out the process including inspections. He advised that the budget is an inaugural budget and it is hoped to secure more funding in the future. The aim is to encourage people to be responsible and to formulate a group together. The application process will remain open and will be on a first come basis with equal distribution throughout the county. He added that the application does not have to be a continuous length of road however, the minimum application is 5km. The council does not enforce cutting unless there are safety or environmental issues. The main aim is to initiate the scheme and the process will be monitored and reviewed

Cllr. Ruddle highlighted people who are renting land and maybe living in another county and hedge cutting is not a priority.

Cllr. E. Ryan queried if the cutting will be one side or both sides of hedge and if a contractor can cut without permission of landowner. He added that the first and second notice sent by the Council to landowners to cut hedgerows is working. Mr. Gannon clarified that this is a separate scheme and consent is required from landowners. It is not intended to stop the issuing of letters, as the aim is to encourage hedge owners to be responsible and cut their hedges. He confirmed that 570 letters were issued in the Newcastle West area last year. In relation to grants being successful according to area, Mr. Gannon advised this is not an obligation and the primary aim is to use the grant funding available.

Cllr. J. Scanlon asked how far communities can be dispersed to avail of grant, in terms of communities, as it may not be 5 kms. Mr. Gannon again stressed, the main aim this year is to receive applications, dispersion has not been decided on. Cllr. J. Scanlan suggested advertising the fact that people can join together. Mr. Gannon replied that there will be a media campaign for the scheme.

Cllr. E. Secas welcomed the scheme but hopes it will be inclusive of community groups and not just landowners and that the 5km restriction would not apply to community groups. In addition, she would like to see a specific time limit for processing applications and an exemption from the law prohibiting hedge cutting if there is a health and safety risk. She also asked if there will be an update of the scheme before the budget is passed next November.

Mr. Gannon stressed this is not a policy, it is a grant scheme. We have to start with conditions but we will monitor and take on board all suggestions. There is no exemption from the law. The local authority will identify if there is a health and safety risk during the exemption period. The SPC and Elected Members will be updated on this scheme in advance of next year's budget.

Cllr. A. Tesky believed the issuing of notices was not productive and the law needs to be enforced. There was a time when LCCC cut all the hedgerows but then it was put back on the communities. €50 is minimal payment and cutting hedges is tedious work. There should be some discretion if individual landowners cannot make the 5km. District engineers are overworked, there should be a specific officer for this scheme. He asked how many enforcement letters were issued last year.

Mr. Gannon replied that the Council has to comply with the law of the state and notices will continue to be issued. He accepted that District Engineers are busy however, we are at the start of the grant process and over time the engineers will have support of admin teams. He did not have the information on the number of enforcements to hand. Again, this scheme is to encourage communities to come together, he accepted the grant is limited but it is a start. He will circulate the information requested to members.

Cllr. S. Kiely asked if this is not a policy, her notice of motion should not be discussed or on the Agenda in this committee, as this committee is for policy only. Cllr. B. Teefy replied that this was referred from a previous full council meeting and was appropriate to be discussed at the SPC meeting. Cllr. S. Kiely replied, she was aware of the origin but anything operational should not be on the Agenda, as the SPC is for policy only.

Mr. Kennedy stated that this was brought up at a budget meeting 2024 and he suggested bringing it to the SPC for agreement and proceeding. This committee is to make recommendations to full council for adoption.

Cllr. J. O'Donoghue stated a well maintained hedgerow is good for everyone including pedestrians and cyclists and welcomes the scheme. He had 8 observations.

1. Application form, is it difficult to complete?
2. Inspection, is this before and after?
3. Trees on the hedges?
4. Local roads only?
5. Are we cutting inside and outside?
6. It costs €80 per hr. for a hedge cutter and €240 per km to cut a well maintained hedge.
7. Will the cost of monitoring the scheme be taken out of the €50K?
8. Will a registered contractor undertake the work?

Mr. B. Kennedy advised that this is a way for multiple landowners to come together. He confirmed that there is 4,000 km of roads in County Limerick, with 3,000 of them are local roads. The council also cuts junctions on regional roads. (Contractor cost is €80 per hour approx.).

Regarding multiple landowners, Mr. Kennedy advised that the scheme is to try to incentivise people under the Roads Act to maintain hedgerows. It is the responsibility of the landowner not the Council to ensure the certification of the contractor. This is a good starting point and the team will revert back to members prior to the next budget meeting in October.

With regard to cutting the hedge inside or outside, Mr. Gannon advised that the purpose is to make safe and this continues to be the case. It will be the section facing the road which will be cut. Regarding the top of hedge, it will whatever is deemed safe. If there are tree limbs, these will be removed. The grant scheme is not prescribed and will apply to all roads

Cllr. O'Donovan welcomed the scheme and asked if people pay first and the work is then carried out or does one wait until application is approved. Cllr. Pond asked about contractor's insurance. Mr. Gannon replied approval is required by LCCC before hedge cutting takes place. He confirmed that the contractor has to be suitably insured which would be the responsibility of the community not the Council.

Cllr E. Ryan queried the functionality of the SPC and stated that he had been a member of 4 SPC's. Mr. Kennedy advised that the SPC is a recommendation body and this item will be referred to the March Plenary meeting of the Council.

Mr. O'Neill stated that there are 300,000 km of hedgerows in the Republic of Ireland and this scheme covers 1,000 km of hedgerows. He asked how it will be prioritized. Mr. Gannon replied that it is a learning process rather than setting targets and there is no set agenda. The primary aim is to encourage people to apply for the grant scheme.

Mrs. M. Browne stated that buses are refusing to travel on minor roads in her area as they are off the beaten track. A lot of people live on these roads who depend on local link transport to collect them and get them out of the house. Mr. Gannon confirmed that the scheme is primarily open to local roads, but will apply to all roads.

The Chair added that the scheme is very welcome and she hopes the landowners renting land will also avail of this grant. An advertisement on radio would be very good medium to get the message out.

It was proposed by Cllr. Eddie Ryan and seconded by Cllr. Jerome Scanlon that the Community Hedge Cutting Grant Scheme be recommended to the Plenary Meeting of the Council Meeting on the 31st March 2025 for adoption.

Two Notice of Motions (a) & (b) were addressed as part of Item 2.

a) Notice of Motion submitted by Councillor S. Kiely (referred from September Council Meeting)

I will move at the next Meeting that this Local Authority examine the possibility of a Community Hedge Cutting Grant.

Reply: Limerick City & County Council is proposing to introduce a Community Hedge Cutting Grant in Q2 of 2025 for application within the hedge cutting period between the 1st of September 2025 and 1st March 2026.

Limerick City & County Council intends to provide a grant up to a maximum of €50 per km of roadside hedge/overhanging trees to be cut with a minimum length of road network to be incorporated in any application of 5km.

b) Notice of Motion submitted by Councillor J. Pond (referred from September Council Meeting)

I will move at the next Meeting that Limerick City and County Council would adopt a policy of cutting Hedges/Trees between the months of September to March that are a danger to all road users, including pedestrians, cyclists and vehicles owners, thus preventing serious accidents from occurring on all our roads.

Reply: Landowners and occupiers of land are obliged to take all reasonable care to ensure that trees, ditches, hedges and other vegetation growing on their land are not or could not become a danger to people using or working on a public road. Examples of hazards might be dead or dying trees, ditches or hedges interfering with traffic, blocking footpaths, obscuring road signs or obscuring a view of the road ahead.

Limerick City & County Council is proposing to introduce a Community Hedge Cutting Scheme and grant which will be open to the public in Q2 of 2025 for application within the hedge cutting period between the 1st September 2025 and 1st March 2026.

Limerick City & County Council intends to provide a grant up to a maximum of €50 per km of roadside hedge/overhanging trees to be cut with a minimum length of road network to be incorporated in any application of 5km.

Item 3: Notice of Motion submitted by Councillor J. O'Donoghue (referred from Adare-Rathkeale September Municipal Meeting)

I will move at the next meeting that a plan for verge trimming on a year-round basis be implemented by L.C.C.C on all roads under the control of the Local Authority.

The Notice of Motion was proposed by Cllr. John O'Donoghue and seconded by Cllr. J Scanlon.

In proposing the Motion, Cllr. O'Donoghue highlighted areas around schools where weeds and vegetation hinder and make it difficult for pedestrians and cyclists. The cutting should start earlier as it is too late when vegetation is well established.

Reply: Landowners and occupiers of land are obliged to take all reasonable care to ensure that trees, ditches, hedges and other vegetation growing on their land are not or could not become a danger to people using or working on a public road. Examples of hazards might be dead or dying trees, ditches or hedges interfering with traffic, blocking footpaths, obscuring road signs or

obscuring a view of the road ahead. The maintenance of verges or margins on regional and local roads is the responsibility of the local authority.

Works on regional and local roads are funded by local authorities' own resources and State grants. Within the overall resources available to Limerick City & County Council, the Council carry out a selection and prioritisation of these works including the maintenance of road verges. The council limits the extent of verge cutting during the months of March to August in order to protect the environment and biodiversity. Any verge cutting is carried out for road safety reasons.

Limerick City & County Council's has the following priorities for verge trimming/hedge cutting:

- All national routes.
- Where safety issues are identified at
 1. Approaches to towns and villages on regional and local roads,
 2. Strategic routes linking towns and villages.
 3. Bus routes and important school bus routes.
 4. Roads being strengthened/surface dressed on the roadworks programme.

Mr. Gannon added that this is different to the Hedge Cutting Grant Scheme. He will take away all comments from the meeting and is happy to explore further options with members.

Cllr. Secas agreed with members regarding overgrowth and added she was not supportive of verge cutting all year round for the purpose of protecting bio diversity. In response, Mr. Gannon advised that cutting will be limited and works will continue to limit the extent of verge cutting during the months of March to August.

Cllr. J. O'Donoghue understood that funding comes into the process and accepted the response.

Item 4: Notice of Motion submitted by Councillor P. Doyle (referred from September Metro Meeting)

I will move at the next Meeting of the Metropolitan District of Limerick that free parking for one hour be allowed for cars on street parking currently designated as loading bays from 14.00 PM to 18.00 PM Monday to Friday on a trial basis for three months. The objective of this measure is to encourage shoppers into Limerick City and increase footfall in William Street and Cruises Street and surrounding areas. The only cost to this measure is amending signage on the poles with appropriate stickers.

The Notice of Motion was proposed by Cllr. P. Doyle and seconded by Cllr. T. Ruddle.

Reply: Most drivers are likely to opt for free parking in loading bays, which could force commercial vehicles to double park and could have significant impact on businesses' ability to get deliveries. The Transport Strategy team is working on installing sensors in loading bays to help commercial drivers locate and book a bay to make it easier to facilitate deliveries. The City

Transport Plan is currently underway and is incorporating a Delivery Strategy and this Notice of Motion will be considered as part of that.

Cllr. O'Donovan did not wish to second the motion. If there is free parking, revenue is lost and there is more that the council can do to help people living in the city. It is not by giving free parking that we bring people into the city.

Cllr. Ruddle disagreed, stating that policy is a big issue. The Council should be more proactive in bringing life to the city. Free parking is a start, what we're doing is wrong.

Following discussion, Cllr. P Doyle added that it is a struggle to be a retailer in the city. He advised that he was not proposing free parking in the city. He accepted the response and proposed to remove the word 'free' from the motion and submit to Mr. H. McGrath for discussion, as part of the development of the Limerick City Transport Plan.

Item 5: Notice of Motion submitted by Councillor J. Leddin (referred from October Metro Meeting)

I will move at the next Meeting of the Metropolitan District of Limerick that this Council amend our traffic calming policy to allow the delivery of traffic calming measures where an elected member provides the funding, and the necessary petition is signed and submitted by residents.

In proposing Cllr. Leddin's motion, Cllr. Secas stated that the process needs to change. The Notice of Motion to amend the policy was proposed by Cllr. Leddin and seconded by Cllr. Secas.

Reply: Limerick City & County Council approved an updated Traffic Calming policy in April 2024. A core principle of the updated policy is that each location is assessed using a marking system to ensure a consistent approach that includes all relevant factors to determine what measure if any is justified. The justification for and type of traffic calming measure to be provided must be considered and appraised by the operational team following a stepped approach before ultimately considering physical measures.

The appraisal system requires approval from the Senior Engineer of the Roads, Traffic and Cleansing Department (or their delegate) to approve the installation of traffic calming features. Where an elected member believes that a measure is needed, they are advised to consult with the relevant district engineer for advice on likely compliance and to ensure that any further assessment of measures can be justified and not wasteful.

Following on from discussion, Mr. Hugh McGrath invited Cllr. Leddin and Cllr. Secas to meet with him and Mr. J Gannon for further discussions on the matter. Cllr. Leddin welcomed the response and the proposal to advance discussion.

Item 6: Notice of Motion submitted by Councillor P. Doyle (referred from October Metro Meeting)

I will move at the next Meeting of the Metropolitan District of Limerick that Limerick City and County Council would present to city centre retailers at no cost parking ticket books in January 2025 provided the retailers have paid their 2024 rates in full. I would suggest large retailers who pay more than €20K in rates receive a 100 book of tickets and all other retailers 25 books of tickets to distribute free parking tickets to their customers in Limerick City centre. A provision for such a scheme should also be included in the Councils 2025 Budget process.

The motion was proposed by Cllr. P. Doyle and seconded by Cllr. J. O'Donoghue.

In proposing the Motion, Cllr. Doyle highlighted the closures of retailer units in the city in recent times and added that people need to be encouraged to shop in the city.

Reply: Budgetary provision was not made in the 2025 Budget to fund this proposed scheme. However, Limerick City and County Council will continue to support city centre retailers with supports approved in the Council's Annual Budget and other supports through the Local Enterprise Office. These supports include but are not limited to the following:

- Small & Medium Business Support Scheme which provides a grant payment of 13.5% of 2025 Rates (subject to a maximum limit of €1,500) for small businesses with a total commercial rate bill of less than €30,000.
- The Councils marketing department will work with stakeholders to assist with marketing and promotion of events.
- Continue to work with city centre business on programme of events to encourage footfall.
- Continue to provide social media platform for business to promote their goods.

Specific budgetary provision for this and other SME schemes can also be considered as part of the Statutory Budget 2026 process.

Following discussion, Mr. Kennedy reiterated that the motion can only be considered as part of the budget process in November 2025. Cllr. Doyle welcomed the response and advised that the request is for a small low cost scheme. Cllr. Ruddle supported the request.

Mr. Kennedy added that the item can be referred to the Limerick City Centre Taskforce Group (chaired by Cllr. Maria O'Donoghue) for consideration. Cllr. Doyle will pass on as an item of interest to the Limerick City taskforce group for consideration.

Item 7: Notice of Motion submitted by Councillor E. Secas (referred from October Metro Meeting)

I will move at the next Meeting of the Metropolitan District of Limerick that the Mayor and the Director General liaise with UL and An Garda Síochána, to set up and chair a taskforce to address car parking problems in residential areas around the University of Limerick.

In proposing the Motion, Cllr. Secas stated that children have to use the road to walk as cars are parked on footpaths. Elderly people are frightened to walk and a taskforce needs to be set up.

The notice of Motion was proposed by Cllr. Secas and seconded by Cllr. Hartigan.

Reply: The University of Limerick (UL) community liaison group, which includes representatives from Limerick City and County Council (LCCC), An Garda Síochána (AGS), UL, and local residents, is actively seeking solutions to the ongoing parking issues. Despite the LCCC Traffic Warden issuing tickets, the problem persists.

Previously, LCCC and AGS led the "Think Before You Park" campaign, with AGS patrolling the areas last year. The parking problems are largely due to the high number of properties rented to multiple residents. While private student accommodations have started charging for parking permits, the public roads have limited capacity, and the demand for parking remains high.

LCCC cannot target students specifically; all illegally parked vehicles are subject to enforcement when the Traffic Warden patrols residential areas.

Mr. Kennedy advised that the motion can be referred to the next Metropolitan meeting. Cllr. Secas welcomed the proposal.

The members agreed to refer this Notice of Motion to the March Metropolitan meeting.

Item 8: Question submitted by Councillor E. Secas (referred from September Council Meeting)

I will ask at the next Meeting if Limerick City and County Council will introduce in its forthcoming budget a Community Hedge Cutting Grant Scheme to assist communities, groups of local residents and landowners with the cutting of dangerous overhanging hedges/tree branches along public roads, similar to the schemes provided by Clare/Leitrim/Cork County Councils.

REPLY:

Limerick City & County Council is proposing to introduce a Community Hedge Cutting Grant in Q2 of 2025 for application within the hedge cutting period between the 1st September 2025 and 1st March 2026.

Limerick City & County Council intends to provide a grant up to a maximum of €50 per km of roadside hedge/overhanging trees to be cut with a minimum length of road network to be incorporated in any application of 5km.

Item 9: Update on provision of salt to Resident's Associations during extreme weather conditions

With the proposal from the Chair, this item was deferred to the next SPC meeting.

Item 10: Update on Bus Connects programme.

Mr. Hugh McGrath delivered an update on the Bus Connects Programme as part of the draft Traffic Management plan for Limerick city outlining the following -

- Park & Ride sites at terminus of Bus routes at Raheen, Mackey and Coonagh being advanced through planning and land acquisition state.
- Bus Stop review with the NTA well advanced for implementation of improvements over 2025 & 2026 with detail design now underway.
- Bus Priority options & Limerick City Centre Transport Plan currently at Option (stage 4) identification & Development stage.
- Improved services as set out under the Network Redesign with the 70% improvement in levels of service expected to be delivered by 2027.

Members thanked Mr. McGrath for the update and requested that an invitation be extended to (Bus Connects Team, NTA) to provide an update on Bus Connects Limerick. Mr. McGrath will extend an invitation and revert to members.

In the interim, Mr. McGrath advised members to direct queries regarding the existing bus services to the NTA and the Transport Strategy Team.

The Chair thanked all for their attendance and contribution. This concluded the business of the meeting.